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The Harvest Festival

Sterling Castle, Norfolk, Autumn 1851

Scene 5 · The kitchen garden and the long gallery

By half past eleven the house had gone quiet the way it always did after a festival dinner, not all at once but a room at a time, as if someone were walking through it putting out the noise like candles. Alexander had gone up, and undressed, and lain for half an hour under two blankets without getting warm, and then he had dressed again and gone down by the back stair in his shirt and an old coat to stand somewhere that was honestly cold, which seemed better.

The kitchen garden was dark. There was no moon. The cloud that had come up in the afternoon had settled over the whole county like a lid, and the only light came from the house behind him, a few late windows: the kitchen, where someone was still scouring pans, and high up at the end of the east range, in the tall windows of the long gallery, a single candle. Catherine, he thought. She never could sleep after company. The garden smelled of turned earth and the last of the fennel, sharp and sweet where he brushed it, and beyond the low wall at the bottom the dark went on without any shape at all.

Niall was standing at the end of the bean rows.

He had his coat on and his hands in his pockets, and he was not doing anything, not smoking, not walking. He was simply standing in the middle of the cabbages at midnight, facing the wall, the way he had stood at the chalk line that afternoon facing the trees. He did not turn round. He had heard Alexander come down the steps; Alexander had never once in six years got near him without being heard.

"You're on watch," Alexander said.

"I'm taking the air."

"In the dark. Among the cabbages."

"They're quiet company." Niall did not look away from the wall. "Unlike some."

Alexander came and stood beside him. It was a little warmer there, or he imagined it was. Up in the chestnuts along the drive there was not a sound. He had not noticed until now that the rooks had never come back.

"You saw something this afternoon," he said. "In the trees."

"I saw rooks."

"You saw what put them up."

Niall did not answer that. Alexander was trying to decide whether to push it, and was finding again, as he had at the chalk line, that he would rather do almost anything than ask a plain question and be given a plain nothing in return, when something moved on top of the garden wall.

He did not see it so much as see the dark change shape. A piece of the night at the top of the wall, forty yards off, was blacker than the rest, and then it was larger, and then there was a sound like a heavy cloak thrown open, once, and a gust of air came across the cabbages and lifted the hair off his forehead.

Niall was already moving.

He did not run, exactly. He went down the path between the bean rows at a long, quick, silent stride, and when he came to the wall he went over it without breaking that stride, one hand on the coping, and was gone.

"Stay there, Alex," came back over the wall, low.

Alexander did not stay there. He went down the path after him as fast as he could in the dark, which was not fast, and turned his ankle on the edge of a bed, and caught himself, and reached the wall. It was chest-high. He put his hands on it and looked over into the paddock beyond, and there was nothing. No Niall. No shape. Only the dark, and the wet smell of grass,

and very far off the sound of the last of the festival, a single drunk voice singing on the hill road, going home.

He listened. He heard nothing move in the paddock. He heard nothing in the air. He stood with his hands on the cold coping and was aware, all at once and absurdly, that he was afraid, and that he had no idea of what.

It was perhaps five minutes before Niall came back. Alexander heard him this time, his boots in the wet grass, and then he came over the wall the way he had gone, lightly, and dropped down beside him breathing hard. He had something in his hand.

"What was it?"

Niall held it up into what little light came from the kitchen window. It was a feather. It was a wing feather, a flight feather, dark and barred with a paler brown, the vane stiff and whole and the quill as thick as a pen. And it was long. It was longer than Alexander's forearm from elbow to fingertip. He knew every large bird in the county. He had seen herons stand in the Fen and swans come down on the river, and when he was a small boy his father had taken him out on the brecks near Thetford to see the last of the great bustards, a pair of them, before they were gone from Norfolk for good. None of them had ever carried a feather like that.

"What is it?" he said again.

Niall looked at the feather for a moment. His face in the window light was perfectly calm, and perfectly closed, in a way Alexander had seen once already that day. Then he opened his coat and put the feather inside it.

"Nothing you need to carry tonight," he said.

It was what his father had done on the steps with the letter. It was the same small movement, the coat opened, the thing put away against the chest, the coat closed over it, and Alexander, standing with his hands still on the wall, understood that he had now been shut out of two things in one day by the two men he would most have liked to be let in by.

"Go up," Niall said, more gently. "You'll take cold."

"I've been cold since six o'clock."

Niall looked at him then, really looked, for the first time since he had come down the steps. Whatever he was going to say, he did not say it. "Go up anyway," he said.

Alexander went. At the top of the kitchen steps he turned. Niall had not moved from the wall. He was standing where Alexander had left him, with his back to the house and his hand flat against his coat over the place where the feather was, looking out into a dark that had nothing in it. And high above the garden, in the tall windows at the end of the long gallery, the single candle was still burning.

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Catherine had come to the long gallery because it was the one room in the house where nobody ever was.

She had brought one candle and set it on the sill of the last window, and she sat on the window seat beside it with her feet tucked up under the green silk and her back against the cold glass, and listened to the house finish being loud. It was like the last bars of a piece played by too many people: one by one they lifted their bows, and the sound got thinner, and in the end there was only the clock on the landing and her own heart going, rather fast still, from the claret, or the evening, or the Iron Gates.

The Iron Gates. She had them in her head and could not get them out. Cliffs so close the sun only touched the water for an hour. Whirlpools that turned a barge end for end. Doors painted blue. She had the place on a map already, she was nearly sure, on the page of her atlas where the Danube came down out of Hungary and went through the mountains in a thin blue thread, and she had touched that thread a hundred times without knowing there was anything there to touch. Now there was. Now there was a fortress on a crag and a wind that never stopped. She wanted it so badly that it felt like hunger, and she sat with it in the candlelight, and was ashamed, and did not let it go.

Down the length of the gallery her great-great-grandmothers looked at her out of their frames. Every one of them had been painted indoors. She had noticed it when she was twelve and never been able to stop noticing it: a Sterling woman in a blue room, a Sterling woman in a red room, a Sterling woman with a spaniel in a room with a window behind her, and through the window, very small, the park, painted in as an afterthought. Great-grandmamma Harriet had

never once been out of Norfolk and had been proud of it all her life. She hung by the door, in grey, holding a prayer book, looking pleased.

Down in the garden somebody called out, a man's voice, low and short. Alexander's, she thought, and then not, and then she did not think about it any further, because when she turned her head from the window the Count was standing six feet away from her in the candlelight.

She had not heard him come. That was odd, a little, on those boards; they had sung under every footstep since she was a child, and Alexander could not cross the gallery without it announcing him like a herald. But the Count was a foreigner, and a light man for his height, and perhaps the boards were kinder to people they did not know. She found that she was not frightened. She found that she was rather glad.

"Forgive me," he said. "I have startled you."

"No. I didn't hear you, that's all. Everyone else in this house sounds like a dropped tray." She did not get up, though she knew she ought to, and he did not seem to expect it. "Are you lost, Count? People get lost. It's a very badly designed house. It was built by four different Sterlings who all disliked each other."

"I was looking at your ancestors." He turned his head to the long row of them, unhurried. "They are very handsome. And very still."

"They're always indoors," Catherine said. "Have you noticed? Every one of them. I used to think it was the painter's fault."

"And now?"

She looked at Great-grandmamma Harriet with her prayer book. "Now I think it's the family's."

He did not laugh, as most people would have, to show her that she was being amusing. He came a little nearer, into the light, and stood at the end of the window seat with his hands behind his back, and looked at her. His face in the candlelight was pale and grave and kind, and he was waiting for her to say more, and it came to her that nobody in her life had ever simply waited for her to say more. People waited for her to finish.

"What do you want of your life, Lady Catherine?" he asked.

It was such a strange thing for a man to ask, and he asked it so quietly, as if it were the only question in the world worth asking, that she answered it. Not with what she wanted. She had never said what she wanted to anyone, not even to Alex, and she did not say it now. She said what she was going to have.

"Oh, it's all arranged," she said. "It's very simple. I shall be proper. I am already quite proper, you know, when anyone's looking. In a year or two Papa will find someone suitable, and he will be a perfectly good man with a perfectly good house in a perfectly good county, probably this one, and I shall go and live in his rooms instead of my father's. I shall have very nice rooms. I shall choose the curtains. And one day someone will paint me in one of them, with a spaniel, and they'll hang me down there next to Great-grandmamma, and some girl will sit here on this seat in a hundred years and wonder why I never went outside." She heard her own voice go thin at the end, and laughed to cover it. "That's all. It's a very good life. Everyone says so."

The Count was quiet for a moment. The candle flame stood perfectly straight between them; there was no draught in the gallery at all.

"That sounds less like a life than a waiting room."

Catherine went still.

It was the thing. It was the exact thing, the thought she had carried about with her since she was twelve years old and had never once let out of her mouth, not to her mother and not to Alex and not to Bess, not even to the page of the atlas where she kept everything else. A waiting room. A room full of very nice chairs where you sat with your hands in your lap until someone came to the door and called your name, and then you went into another room exactly like it. She had never found the words for it, and this man had walked out of the dark and handed them to her as if she had dropped them.

Something loosened in her chest, warm and frightening, like the first notes of a piece she had wanted all her life to be able to play.

"Yes," she said. "That's exactly what it is."

He inclined his head, as though she had confirmed something he had already known.

"I am to call on your father on Tuesday," he said, "about a little wet meadow I saw from the road. I think he will not wish to sell it to me."

"Harrow's Fen?" She laughed, and this time it was real. "No. He won't. He'd sooner sell me."

The Count looked at her. He did not laugh with her. He only looked, with that grave, kind, waiting face, until her laugh ran out of its own accord and left the gallery very quiet.

"Goodnight, Lady Catherine," he said, and bowed, and went back down the long gallery between her painted grandmothers, and she did not hear his steps on the boards at all.

She sat on in the window seat after he had gone, with her arms round her knees. The candle had burned down to a stub. Outside the tall windows the night was perfectly black, without a star, and somewhere below in the garden a man was standing by the wall, but she did not look down to see who. She was thinking of a gorge where the sun reached the water for one hour in the day. She was thinking that someone had finally said it out loud.

She wanted very much to hear him say it again.

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Added Details not in Scene Packet

Every detail in this scene that its scene packet does not supply, in the order it appears. Items marked *decided* have since been approved and recorded in the planning documents. Everything else is open to change in the next draft.

The garden

- Alexander goes down the back stair in an old coat because he cannot get warm.
- Someone is still scouring pans in the kitchen. A single candle burns in the long gallery.
- Niall stands among the cabbages: "They're quiet company. Unlike some."
- The shape on the wall is forty yards off and sounds "like a heavy cloak thrown open."
- Niall: "Stay there, Alex."
- Alexander turns his ankle on a bed edge. Beyond the wall is a paddock, and a drunk man is singing on the hill road.
- Niall is gone about five minutes.
- The feather is barred dark brown, longer than Alexander's forearm, with a quill as thick as a pen.
- Edward once took Alexander to the brecks near Thetford to see the last great bustards in Norfolk.
- Niall pockets the feather with the same movement as Edward pocketing the letter.
- "Go up. You'll take cold." "I've been cold since six o'clock."

The gallery

- Catherine sets one candle on the sill and sits in the window seat in green silk. The clock is on the landing.
- She has the Iron Gates on her atlas page "in a thin blue thread."
- Every ancestor portrait was painted indoors. She noticed it at twelve.
- Great-grandmamma Harriet never left Norfolk, is painted in grey with a prayer book, and hangs by the door.
- She hears a man's voice in the garden.

- The gallery boards sing under everyone else, and Alexander crosses them "like a herald."
- The house was built by four Sterlings who disliked each other.
- Catherine's future: "very nice rooms," choosing the curtains, a portrait with a spaniel.
- The candle flame stands straight; there is no draught.
- "Like the first notes of a piece she had wanted all her life to be able to play."
- Hessian will call on Edward on Tuesday "about a little wet meadow I saw from the road."
- "He'd sooner sell me." Hessian does not laugh.
- Catherine does not hear his steps leaving.